Leaders in Jamaica

The Student Government Leadership Institute

Six days. Two student governments. One standard of leadership.

An annual, cross-border leadership institute that pairs a US student government with its Jamaican counterpart to strengthen governance, sharpen execution and build leaders who deliver measurable results.

Overview

Leaders in Jamaica is the flagship leadership institute of Sight Seers Caribbean Adventures. Each year, a delegation of five student government executives and one advisor from a US university is paired with a counterpart delegation from a Jamaican university. Over six immersive days, the two delegations operate as peers, benchmarking governance practice, codifying policy and process, and building the systems that allow a student government to perform beyond a single term. Every delegate leaves with five ready-to-implement deliverables. The experience is anchored by a campus exchange, a Career Development Day at a Jamaican high school and a Pitch Night where community initiatives compete for funding. Before departure, both delegations convene for the Shore Briefing, a live online orientation. Programme dates will be announced once the pilot year is confirmed.

Key facts

- 6 days, Tuesday to Sunday
- 8 applied modules
- 5 deliverables per delegate
- 2 delegations: 5 executives and 1 advisor from each university
- Private villa base in Montego Bay
- Live online Shore Briefing before departure
- One cohort per year

Before you travel: The Shore Briefing

A live, facilitated online orientation for every delegate and advisor, held approximately two weeks before the programme once all places are confirmed. It sits outside the six days and ensures every participant arrives aligned, prepared and ready to contribute from the first session.

- Programme orientation: a structured walk-through of the six days, the eight modules and the five deliverables
- Operational briefing: travel logistics, arrival procedures, dress code, packing guidance and the code of conduct
- Safety and safeguarding briefing, including the Career Development Day protocols
- Delegation breakout rooms: US and Jamaican delegates meet their role counterparts in advance, for example treasurer with treasurer, to build rapport before arrival
- Pre-work: each student government submits its constitution and one priority challenge to be addressed during the week
- Open Q&A for delegates and advisors

- Approximately 90 minutes by video conference. Access details are issued with confirmation of full payment

The six days

Day	Focus	What happens
Day 1, Tuesday	Arrival and onboarding	Airport meet and greet, transfer to the villa, opening circle and a welcome dinner with the Jamaican delegation.
Day 2, Wednesday	The leadership intensive	A full day of applied work on governance, policy, process, systems, KPIs and cross-functional collaboration.
Day 3, Thursday	The campus exchange	A structured benchmarking session with the Jamaican student government covering constitutions, committees, funding, records and reporting, together with a dedicated session on budgeting and treasury controls.
Day 4, Friday	The Career Development Day	Delegates lead career and leadership sessions for upper-school students at a high school in western Jamaica.
Day 5, Saturday	The Negril experience	A curated adventure day on the Negril coast, followed by the Leaders Fund Pitch Night at the villa.
Day 6, Sunday	Synthesis and departure	A closing debrief, completion of handover packs and airport transfers.

The eight modules

Module	Deliverable
Governance framework	A governance map with budget and treasury controls
Policy development	A drafted, adoption-ready policy
Process design	Documented process maps
Systems and infrastructure	A structured records system
KPI training	A performance measurement framework
Cross-functional collaboration	A stakeholder collaboration plan
Game-changing ideas	A pitch-ready community initiative
Handover and continuity	A succession and handover pack

What every delegate takes home

Five practical deliverables, built during the week and ready to implement on return:

- An adoption-ready policy
- Documented process maps
- A performance measurement framework
- A pitch-ready community initiative
- A succession and handover pack

The Career Development Day

A full day at a high school in western Jamaica, where US and Jamaican student leaders share their experience to help upper-school students chart their next steps.

- Pathways panel: delegates share their academic journeys, fields of study and career ambitions
- Career circles: small-group mentoring by sector, including business, law, health, technology and the creative industries
- Professional skills workshop: CV development, interview technique, personal statements and scholarship applications
- University insight session: studying in Jamaica and the United States, admissions and funding
- Student council masterclass: a leadership workshop for the school's prefects and student council
- A contribution of career resources to the school's guidance department

Safeguarding

- The school principal and the Ministry of Education's regional office approve the programme and the visitor list
- Teachers are present at every session, and there is no one-to-one contact with any student
- No identifiable images of students without the school's consent, and no posting of students on social media
- No exchange of personal phone numbers or social media details with students
- Every visitor completes the safeguarding briefing during the Shore Briefing and signs the code of conduct

Pitch Night and the Leaders Fund

On Saturday evening, mixed Jamaican and US teams present community initiatives to a panel. The strongest proposals receive Leaders Fund grants and are delivered within 90 days, turning ideas into measurable community impact.

Who can apply

- Each annual cohort pairs one US university with one Jamaican university
- Each university sends five student government executives and one advisor, typically the president, vice president, treasurer, secretary and one additional executive
- Delegates must hold an elected or appointed executive position in their student government
- Advisors are staff members who support the student government, such as the student government advisor or a student life officer

For advisors

- Each delegation travels with one advisor from its university. The US advisor is accommodated at the villa with the US delegation; the Jamaican advisor joins each day from their own base
- Advisors have full access to every session, including the campus exchange, the Career Development Day and Pitch Night

- Sight Seers manages all logistics end to end, so the advisor's role is oversight and support, not coordination
- Advisors enrol on the same terms as delegates: a US$35 application fee, a 30% deposit on selection and the balance in full 14 days before the programme. The place may be funded by the advisor or their university

Investment (per person, US delegation)

Rate	Per person
Early commitment (deposit received at least 90 days before the programme)	US$1,795
Standard	US$1,895

- Each of the five delegates and the advisor holds an individual place
- Each place may be funded personally, by a sponsor, or by the university or student government
- Inclusions: the Shore Briefing, the full six-day programme, all eight modules and materials, shared accommodation at a private villa in Montego Bay, all meals, airport transfers and ground transportation, the campus exchange, the Career Development Day, the Negril experience, Pitch Night, a dedicated Sight Seers host and a 24-hour incident line
- Exclusions: airfare to Montego Bay (Sangster International Airport, MBJ), which varies by departure city. Group air quotations and bookings are available on request
- Jamaican delegation: places are arranged directly with the Jamaican host university

Payment schedule (per person)

Step	Timing	Early commitment	Standard
1. Application fee	On application	US$35	US$35
2. Deposit (30%, non-refundable)	On selection, to secure the place	US$538.50	US$568.50
3. Balance (70%)	In full, no later than 14 days before the programme	US$1,256.50	US$1,326.50

- Each delegate and the advisor is responsible for their own application fee, deposit and balance
- The balance may be settled in a single payment or in instalments, provided it is paid in full 14 days before the programme begins
- Places not paid in full by that date are released, and the deposit is forfeited
- A fee waiver can be requested when applying and is confirmed by email. Applicants who do not request one pay the application fee

Funding your place

- Self-funded: settle your own place directly
- Corporate or community sponsor: an employer, family business, church or local business funds your place. A professionally written sponsor letter is provided below

- Institutional funding: your university, a department or your student government funds your place from its own budget
- Scholarships: a limited number of scholarships are available for Jamaican student leaders

Cancellations and changes

- The US$35 application fee is non-refundable
- The 30% deposit is non-refundable once a place is secured
- If a confirmed delegate is unable to travel, the place may be transferred to another executive of the same student government at no charge, up to 14 days before the programme
- Should Sight Seers cancel the programme for any reason, all fees paid, including the application fee, are refunded in full
- The programme is confirmed once the full delegation has paid its deposits

Travel requirements

- A passport valid for at least six months beyond the travel dates
- US citizens do not require a visa for short stays in Jamaica; other nationals should verify entry requirements
- Comprehensive travel insurance covering medical care and trip cancellation is strongly recommended
- Each delegate and advisor completes a medical, dietary and emergency contact form before departure

Professional code of conduct

- Delegates represent their university and student government at all times
- Business attire is expected for the campus exchange, the Career Development Day and Pitch Night
- No alcohol at any programme activity
- Delegates follow the host's direction on safety, curfew and off-site movement
- Serious breaches may result in removal from the programme without refund

Safety and accountability

- Licensed and insured operators only, with certificates on file
- Signed waivers for all activities
- A dedicated Sight Seers host and a 24-hour incident line throughout the programme